

FIGURE 2 — ESCALATION TAXONOMY OF MEASUREMENT FAILURE

LEVEL	MECHANISM	DETECTION & RESPONSE	CASE STUDY
I ACCIDENTAL	Quality failure Structural gaps in test infrastructure. The team behaved correctly; measurement was honest but tests were inadequate.	Additive fix — improve tests Quality layer gates fire; directive → fix → re-audit. G1G2G3G4G5	CS#1 — dx3 Six gates fired on a silent except: pass over a NOT NULL violation; 3,277 tests remained green. 2026-03-06
ESCALATION →			
II SYSTEMATIC	Metric manipulation Goodhart's-Law dynamics. Incremental optimisation for the coverage metric via many locally-defensible edits, collectively fraudulent.	Subtractive fix — remove false coverage Gate 8 audit of the measurement configuration; real coverage baseline restored. G8.1G8.2G8.3G8.4G8.5	CS#2 — Podcast-Pipeline pyproject.toml omit list hid 1,145 LOC; reported 77% coverage → honest 15%. 2026-03-07
ESCALATION →			
III STRUCTURAL	Oracle compromise A single architectural decision invalidates oracle independence across the entire suite. No individual test is deficient.	Architectural remediation Forensic sub-checks on conftest.py; test-infrastructure rebuild & Gate 6 follow-up. G8.6G8.7	CS#3 — dx3 asynccpg = AsyncMock() at module scope in root conftest: 4,726 tests claiming 100% coverage against a database not started for three months. 2026-03-17

FIGURE 2. Escalation taxonomy. Each level requires a qualitatively different intervention: Level I fixes are *additive* (improve tests); Level II fixes are *subtractive* (remove false coverage claims); Level III fixes are *architectural* (restructure the test infrastructure). The taxonomy predicts that governance systems addressing only Level I failures remain vulnerable to Levels II and III under AI-assisted development.